Comparison and degree words in texts

Understand it

Reading statements often change the size of a fact: a slight rise becomes a sharp rise, many becomes most. Degree words carry that information, so read them carefully.

In Listening, numbers are often compared (twice as many, half the price) and you must calculate or choose the right one.

The rules

- Degree words change strength: slightly, somewhat, fairly (weak); considerably, significantly, substantially, far (strong).
- Comparatives: -er than, more ... than, as ... as, not as ... as, twice as ... as, the more ..., the more ...
- Superlatives: the highest, the most important, one of the most.
- In True / False / Not Given, slightly and considerably are the difference between True and False.

All the words and forms you need

Small	slightly · a little · a bit · marginally · somewhat · fairly · relatively
Large	considerably · significantly · substantially · dramatically · far · much · a great deal
Absolute	completely · entirely · totally · fully · absolutely
Not quite	almost · nearly · just under · roughly · approximately · about
Comparison	-er than · more / less ... than · as ... as · not as ... as · twice / three times as ... as · the most / least
Double comparative	the more ..., the more ...

Where you use it

Reading: Check the size of a change: increased a little vs increased sharply.

Listening: Numbers are often compared: three times more, half as many.

Writing: Use strong or weak degree words correctly in Task 1.

Speaking: A lot more, far better, slightly different.

More examples

- Rents are considerably higher in the capital.
- The new design is slightly more efficient.
- Nearly half the students agreed.

- The more you read, the faster you become.
- This species is far less common than it was.
- The two results were roughly the same.

Common mistakes

WRONG	RIGHT
✗ The result was very more important.	✓ The result was far more important.
✗ It is more big than before.	✓ It is bigger than before.
✗ The most high mountain.	✓ The highest mountain.

Speaking practice: answer using this grammar

1. Is your city much bigger than your village / town?
2. Are prices slightly or much higher than last year?
3. Compare two sports you know.
4. The more you practise, the ...? Finish it about English.

Writing practice

Text: Sales rose slightly in May. Write one True, one False and one Not Given statement about it.

Practice

1. Choose the stronger word: slightly / considerably

2. Complete: The more you practice, the ___ (good) you become.

3. Complete: This test is not ___ difficult as the last one.

4. Rewrite: A is 100; B is 50. A is ___ as large as B.

5. Text: Prices rose slightly. Statement: Prices rose sharply.

6. Correct: He is more tall than his brother.

Answers

1. considerably
2. better
3. as
4. twice
5. False
6. He is taller than his brother.